

An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge

Ambrose Bierce · 1890

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TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Collected_Works_of_Ambrose_Bierce/Volume_2/An_Occurrence_at_Owl_Creek_Bridge (revision 7797523), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge suggest about illusion and reality?
- What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge suggest about war and death?
- What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge suggest about time?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*illusion and reality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge

Focus: the mind's final escape at the moment of death

Content note (execution by hanging, civil war violence): Sensitive content: Execution by hanging; Civil War violence. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes execution by hanging; Civil War violence.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, stands on a railroad bridge in Alabama about to be hanged by Union soldiers. Part II flashes back: a disguised Union scout tempted him to try burning the bridge. In Part III the rope seems to break; he swims, dodges bullets, and walks all night to his home, where his wife waits. As he reaches for her, a blow falls: he is dead, his body swinging beneath the bridge.

Background: Bierce fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga; the story (1890) is in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians.

Significance: A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes execution by hanging; Civil War violence.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are engulfed, pitilessly, inhaled, smashing, carpeted. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!" In this sentence it means: swallowed up completely. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge would have known. Bierce fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga; the story (1890) is in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians. Why does this story matter? A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for structure.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "The man who was engaged in being hanged was apparently about thirty-five years of age." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to the mind's final escape at the moment of death? I circle "assassin", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find structure, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for structure.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of structure. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *The man who was engaged in being hanged was apparently about thirty-five years of age. He was a civilian, if one might judge from his habit, which was that of a planter. His features were good—a straight nose, firm mouth, broad forehead, from which his long, dark hair was combed straight back, falling behind his ears to the collar of his well-fitting frock-coat. He wore a mustache and pointed beard, but no whiskers; his eyes were large and dark gray, and had a kindly expression which one would hardly have expected in one whose neck was in the hemp. Evidently this was no vulgar assassin. The liberal military code makes provision for hanging many kinds of persons, and gentlemen are not excluded.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Structure, Point of view, Imagery: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge develops the idea of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to illusion and reality? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about the mind's final escape at the moment of death, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
engulfed (verb)	swallowed up completely	*He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pitilessly (adverb)	without pity or mercy	*How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured intervals fell those cruel words:*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
inhaled (verb)	breathed in	*The trees upon the bank were giant garden plants; he noted a definite order in their arrangement, inhaled the fragrance of their blooms.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
smashing (noun)	breaking into pieces	*As he shook his head free from the commotion of the smitten water he heard the deflected shot humming through the air ahead, and in an instant it was cracking and smashing the branches in the forest beyond.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
carpeted (verb)	covered as if with a carpet	*How softly the turf had carpeted the untraveled avenue—he could no longer feel the roadway beneath his feet!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
	driving one wild		

maddening (adjective)		*The intervals of silence grew progressively longer; the delays became maddening.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
singsong (noun)	a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation	*The sound of a clear, high voice in a monotonous singsong now rang out behind him and came across the water with a distinctness that pierced and subdued all other sounds, even the beating of the ripples in his ears.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
assassin (noun)	a murderer	*Evidently this was no vulgar assassin.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
etiquette (noun)	rules governing socially acceptable behavior	*In the code of military etiquette silence and fixity are forms of deference.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
insupportable (adjective)	unbearable	*His whole body was racked and wrenched with an insupportable anguish!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever?
2. Where does structure appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with illusion and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Where is Farquhar at the start? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: On a railroad bridge about to be hanged
2. Why is he being executed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge
3. Who tempted him to attack the bridge? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier
4. What does Farquhar seem to experience in Part III? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An escape home to his wife
5. What is the truth at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He has died by hanging

6. Retell the three most important events of "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, stands on a railroad bridge in Alabama about to be hanged by Union soldiers. Part II flashes back: a disguised Union scout tempted him to try burning the bridge. In Part III the rope seems to break; he swims, dodges bullets, and walks all night to his home, where his wife waits. As he reaches for her, a blow falls: he is dead, his body swinging beneath the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!" What does "engulfed" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: engulfed: swallowed up completely.
10. Reread: "How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured intervals fell those cruel words:" What does "pitilessly" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: pitilessly: without pity or mercy.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" suggest about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration.
2. Find one example of structure in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
3. How does the point of view in this story shape what we understand about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
4. In the passage that begins "The man who was engaged in being hanged was apparently about thirty-five years of age.", why might Bierce have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Peyton Farquhar, a Southern planter, stands on a railroad bridge in Alabama about to be hanged by Union soldiers. Part II flashes back: a disguised Union scout tempted him to try burning the bridge. In Part III the rope seems to break; he swims, dodges bullets, and walks all night to his home,…
6. As the opening story, what does "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" set up that the rest of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: "Time can feel slow or fast. When has a moment seemed to last forever?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with illusion and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
10. Background: Bierce fought for the Union at Shiloh and Chickamauga; the story (1890) is in Tales of Soldiers and Civilians. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A celebrated experiment with time and point of view; the twist depends on shifting from objective to subjective narration." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to war and death: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Bierce need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the structure in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" treats the mind's final escape at the moment of death with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve illusion and reality? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the mind's final escape at the moment of death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Ambrose Bierce about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz

1. Where is Farquhar at the start?
   A. On his plantation
   B. In prison
   C. On a railroad bridge about to be hanged
   D. In a boat
2. Why is he being executed?
   A. He deserted the army
   B. He shot an officer
   C. He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge
   D. He stole horses
3. Who tempted him to attack the bridge?
   A. A Confederate general
   B. His wife
   C. A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier
   D. A slave
4. What does Farquhar seem to experience in Part III?
   A. A battle
   B. A pardon
   C. An escape home to his wife
   D. A trial
5. What is the truth at the end?
   A. He was pardoned
   B. He has died by hanging
   C. He dreamed the hanging
   D. He escaped

6. In the line “He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!”, what does “engulfed” most nearly mean?
   A. breaking into pieces
   B. breathed in
   C. without pity or mercy
   D. swallowed up completely
7. In the line “How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured intervals fell those cruel words:”, what does “pitilessly” most nearly mean?
   A. breaking into pieces
   B. swallowed up completely
   C. breathed in
   D. without pity or mercy

Answer key: 1. C (On a railroad bridge about to be hanged); 2. C (He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge); 3. C (A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier); 4. C (An escape home to his wife); 5. B (He has died by hanging); 6. D (swallowed up completely); 7. D (without pity or mercy)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge,” how does Bierce show the mind's final escape at the moment of death? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.W.1): In An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, how does Bierce develop the idea of the mind's final escape at the moment of death? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge develops the idea of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what An Occurrence at Owl

Creek Bridge suggests about the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's structure and point of view), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Ambrose Bierce uses structure in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge to complicate the reader's understanding of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the mind's final escape at the moment of death responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the mind's final escape at the moment of death follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge and its treatment of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's structure and point of view, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge as evidence for a larger claim about the mind's final escape at the moment of death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the mind's final escape at the moment of death. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge.

SAT-style questions

1. *The trees upon the bank were giant garden plants; he noted a definite order in their arrangement, inhaled the fragrance of their blooms.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “inhaled” most nearly mean?

   A. unbearable

B. breathed in

C. rules governing socially acceptable behavior

D. a murderer

2. *The man who was engaged in being hanged was apparently about thirty-five years of age. He was a civilian, if one might judge from his habit, which was that of a planter. His features were good—a straight nose, firm mouth, broad forehead, from which his long, dark hair was combed straight back, falling behind his ears to the collar of his well-fitting frock-coat. He wore a mustache and pointed beard, but no whiskers; his eyes were large and dark gray, and had a kindly expression which one would hardly have expected in one whose neck was in the hemp. Evidently this was no vulgar assassin. The liberal military code makes provision for hanging many kinds of persons, and gentlemen are not excluded.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge"?

A. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

B. Self-destruction and the urge to do wrong

C. Racial pride destroying love

D. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

SAT key: 1. B (breathed in); 2. D (The mind's final escape at the moment of death)

Whole-book test

An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Where is Farquhar at the start?
   A. On his plantation
   B. In prison
   C. On a railroad bridge about to be hanged
   D. In a boat
2. Why is he being executed?
   A. He deserted the army
   B. He shot an officer
   C. He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge
   D. He stole horses
3. Who tempted him to attack the bridge?
   A. A Confederate general
   B. His wife
   C. A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier
   D. A slave
4. What does Farquhar seem to experience in Part III?
   A. A battle
   B. A pardon
   C. An escape home to his wife
   D. A trial
5. What is the truth at the end?
   A. He was pardoned
   B. He has died by hanging
   C. He dreamed the hanging
   D. He escaped
6. In the line “He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his lungs engulfed a great draught of air, which instantly he expelled in a shriek!”, what does “engulfed” most nearly mean?
   A. breaking into pieces
   B. breathed in
   C. without pity or mercy
   D. swallowed up completely

7. In the line “How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured intervals fell those cruel words:”, what does “pitilessly” most nearly mean?
   A. breaking into pieces
   B. swallowed up completely
   C. breathed in
   D. without pity or mercy
8. As used in the story (“He felt his head emerge; his eyes were blinded by the sunlight; his chest expanded convulsively, and with a supreme and crowning agony his l”), what does “engulfed” mean?
   A. swallowed up completely
   B. covered as if with a carpet
   C. a murderer
   D. without pity or mercy
9. As used in the story (“How coldly and pitilessly—with what an even, calm intonation, presaging, and enforcing tranquillity in the men—with what accurately measured”), what does “pitilessly” mean?
   A. driving one wild
   B. without pity or mercy
   C. rules governing socially acceptable behavior
   D. breathed in
10. As used in the story (“The trees upon the bank were giant garden plants; he noted a definite order in their arrangement, inhaled the fragrance of their blooms.”), what does “inhaled” mean?
    A. a regular and monotonous rising and falling intonation
    B. unbearable
    C. breathed in
    D. breaking into pieces
11. As used in the story (“As he shook his head free from the commotion of the smitten water he heard the deflected shot humming through the air ahead, and in an insta”), what does “smashing” mean?
    A. a murderer
    B. swallowed up completely
    C. covered as if with a carpet
    D. breaking into pieces
12. As used in the story (“How softly the turf had carpeted the untraveled avenue—he could no longer feel the roadway beneath his feet!”), what does “carpeted” mean?
    A. covered as if with a carpet
    B. rules governing socially acceptable behavior
    C. without pity or mercy
    D. driving one wild

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how illusion and reality develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how war and death develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how time develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (illusion and reality, war and death, time) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (On a railroad bridge about to be hanged); 2. C (He tried to interfere with the railroad bridge); 3. C (A Federal scout disguised as a Confederate soldier); 4. C (An escape home to his wife); 5. B (He has died by hanging); 6. D (swallowed up completely); 7. D (without pity or mercy); 8. A (swallowed up completely); 9. B (without pity or mercy); 10. C (breathed in); 11. D (breaking into pieces); 12. A (covered as if with a carpet)

Essay assignments

Essay: Illusion and reality

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge teaches about illusion and reality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Ambrose Bierce develops illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Ambrose Bierce develops illusion and reality across An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of illusion and reality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Ambrose Bierce's choices in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of illusion and reality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge's treatment of illusion and reality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Name

your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on illusion and reality in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: War and death

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge teaches about war and death. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Ambrose Bierce develops war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Ambrose Bierce develops war and death across An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of war and death. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Ambrose Bierce's choices in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of war and death, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge's treatment of war and death in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on war and death in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Time

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge teaches about time. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Ambrose Bierce develops time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Ambrose Bierce develops time across An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of time. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Ambrose Bierce's choices in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of time, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge's treatment of time in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on time in An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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